the mountainous heights around the northern Kashmiri town of Kargil, India's firm but measured military response pushed back Pakistani troops. More importantly, it led the US and the world at large to accept that the LoC was now the *de facto* border in Jammu and Kashmir. More importantly, it showed that these two nuclear-armed neighbours could fight a conflict for several weeks, without showing signs of using their nuclear arsenals.

Thereafter, attacks by Pakistani trained and armed militants—including a few suicide attacks—have largely been focused on Indian troops and military installations. However, sometimes, a terror attack on a military installation becomes too serious for the New Delhi Government to ignore; like the one in September 2016 on the rear echelons of an Indian Army base in Uri—on the LoC, along the Srinagar-Muzaffarabad Road—that killed 19 Indian soldiers and left even more wounded. The public outcry—with the media leading the charge—left Prime Minister Modi with little choice. What followed were simultaneous commando raids, popularly referred to as 'surgical strikes', on seven targets, several kilometres across the LoC on terrorist-training camps and their launch pads in POK. It left scores of militants dead with Indian special forces having suffered no casualties. But the Pakistan Army, which zealously guards its image as the guardian of the state, threatened the Indian Government with serious escalation if the details and photographic evidence of these 'strikes' were made public. The Modi government thus chose not to display film footage and other evidence of the strike, even though they briefed diplomats and sections of the media about the remarkable operation. The government's decision to not display evidence allowed his political opponents and all those sympathetic to Pakistan—especially amongst India's liberal intellectuals—to say that it was all a charade. The evidence was eventually made public much later, but by then Pakistan had dismissed it as a doctored publicity stunt!

But almost 30 months later, an explosive-laden vehicle driven by a Kashmiri youth, rammed into a CRPF convoy in Pulwama, on the Jammu-Srinagar highway in February 2019. It left over 40 soldiers dead, and even as the blame game continued within the Indian establishment on why and